

Reading a pitch like a sceptic

Bundle Academy · Portfolio craft · Level 3 · 3 min · Source document for NotebookLM video generation

Traction theatre, TAM fiction and valuation tells: the questions that cut through.

WHAT THIS VIDEO MUST LAND

By the end the viewer should be able to state the argument below in their own words. It is one argument, not a list of tips. Every number is illustrative of published ranges, not a forecast of any specific investment.

- Cumulative charts hide the truth; ask for monthly and cohort data.
- Discount claimed TAM down to what is reachable in five years.
- Price the round against revenue and the last round, not the story.
- Know the runway, the concentration and your share class before investing.

THE ARGUMENT, IN ORDER

1 Traction theatre

Narration: Cumulative charts only go up. Ask for monthly revenue, monthly active users and retention, and watch the shape change.

On screen: A bar chart measured in what the number actually tells you: Cumulative sign-ups = 15 what the number actually tells you; Monthly active users = 65 what the number actually tells you; Monthly recurring revenue = 85 what the number actually tells you; Cohort retention at 6 months = 95 what the number actually tells you.

Hold: about 8 seconds

2 TAM fiction

Narration: A £40bn market is not addressable. Work down to the customers this company can actually reach in five years, then look at the valuation again.

On screen: A bar chart measured in £m, market claimed vs reachable: Total market claimed = 40000 £m, market claimed vs reachable; Segment they can serve = 2200 £m, market claimed vs reachable; Reachable in 5 years = 180 £m, market claimed vs reachable.

Hold: about 8 seconds

3 Valuation tells

Narration: Compare the raise to revenue, not to ambition. A pre-revenue company priced at £15m needs an extraordinary story to justify it.

On screen: A bar chart measured in revenue multiple at the asking price: Mature SaaS comparable = 6 revenue multiple at the asking price; High-growth SaaS = 14 revenue multiple at the asking price; This round = 52 revenue multiple at the asking price.

Hold: about 8 seconds

4 The five questions

Narration: Who is already paying? What happens if the top customer leaves? How long does the cash last? What did the last round price at? What do I own?

On screen: A timeline visual.

Hold: about 8 seconds

5 Scepticism is not cynicism

Narration: The aim is not to talk yourself out of everything. It is to know exactly what you are betting on.

On screen: A stat visual.

Hold: about 6 seconds

THE SAME ARGUMENT IN PROSE

Pitch materials are marketing, and good marketing selects its numbers. That is not dishonesty, it is the format. Your job is to convert the selected numbers back into the underlying ones.

Traction is where this shows up first. Cumulative totals only ever rise, so they carry almost no information. Monthly figures and cohort retention do, because they reveal whether people stay after the launch push ends.

Market sizing is the second. A total addressable market of tens of billions describes an industry, not an opportunity. Work down to the customers this specific company can reach with this specific product within five years, and the valuation has to be defended against that number instead.

Then check what you are actually buying. The last round's price, the current runway, the customer concentration and the share class you are being offered tell you more about your likely outcome than any slide in the deck. If a founder cannot answer those quickly, the difficulty of getting the answer is itself the answer.

TONE AND CONSTRAINTS

- **Never give advice.** Describe how the asset class behaves. Do not tell the viewer what to buy, how much to invest, or that anything is a good opportunity. No "you should", no "we recommend".
- **Do not invent numbers.** Use only the figures in this document. If a figure is not here, leave it out rather than estimating one.
- **Keep the risk honest.** Losing everything is the single most likely outcome for any one early-stage company. Never soften that, and never end on a purely upbeat note that contradicts it.
- **Plain English.** UK spelling. Expand any term the first time it appears. No hype words: no "unlock", "supercharge", "game-changing", "revolutionary".
- **Calm, factual delivery.** This is an explainer, not a pitch. No urgency, no countdowns, no scarcity.
- **No specific companies.** Do not name real companies as examples, and do not imply any listing is available or recommended.

BASIS OF THE FIGURES

Illustrative examples. Nothing here is a comment on any specific company or raise.

Bundle is an aggregator of private-market opportunities listed on third-party venues. It holds no client money, executes no trades and gives no advice. Private-market investments are illiquid, are not covered by the FSCS, and you may lose all the money you invest. This document is educational source material, not a financial promotion.